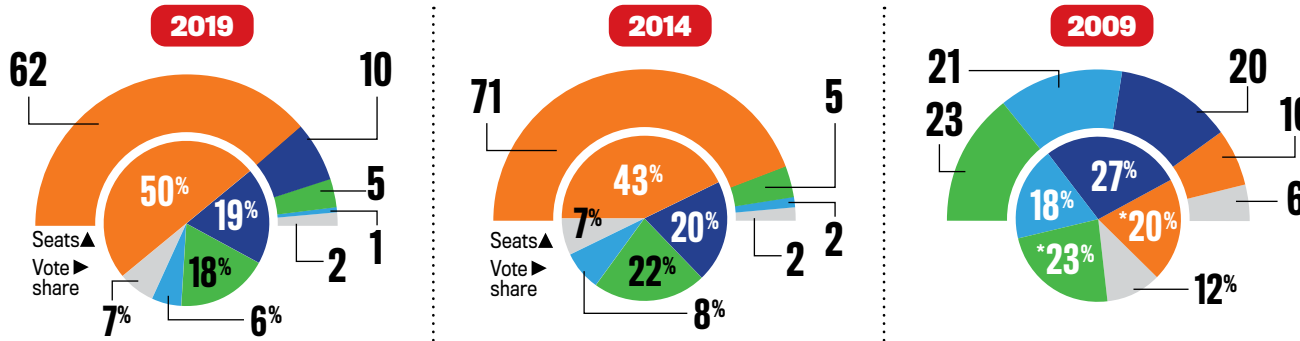
SAFFRON DOMINANCE

The BJP has controlled the narrative and swept the polls since 2014

LOK SABHA ELECTIONS

Total seats: 80



Just two years earlier, the BJP had swept the UP assembly election. The double-engine sarkar and Pulwama-Balakot national security narratives worked in the saffron party's favour

The state was swept away in the Modi wave, especially after he decided to contest from Varanasi. The SP was in power then in UP, but could do little, ending up with just five seats

The last placid election where everyone got a piece of the pie. The Congress got its highest tally in some time. The SP got the highest number of seats even though the BSP got the most votes

BJP BSP SP Congress Others *Vote share figures have been rounded off; * with allies*

bagged all five seats under the Ghazipur LS constituency. In Ghosi, the BJP managed only one of the five assembly seats. This time, the SP has fielded candidates in nine of Purvanchal's 13 seats and the Congress in four. The tricky element for them is the BSP, which is in the game in all 13 seats and is also striking beyond its core—with six OBC and three Pasmanda Muslim candidates.

The most high-voltage arena is the PM's constituency, Varanasi. In 2014, when Modi first contested here, he won with an epic-scale margin of 372,000-plus votes, and a 56.37 per cent vote share overall, against second-placed Arvind Kejriwal of the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP). In 2019, his victory margin increased to 459,000-plus votes—with a 63.6 per cent vote share overall—against his nearest rival, Shalini Yadav of the SP, who soon joined the BJP. Talking to INDIA TODAY, UP Congress chief and Modi's present opponent Ajay Rai claims: "This time, change is coming to Kashi also. It's an outsider versus local fight." On a more serious note, Rai may happily seek solace in a 'moral victory' if he can even trim that margin slightly.

In Mirzapur, where AD(S) chief Anupriya Patel is seeking her third straight tenure, the SP has played a neat hand by fielding Ramesh Bind, outgoing BJP MP from neighbouring Bhadohi, who switched to the SP after being denied a ticket. This is part of the SP's PDA outreach, which seeks to shore up its old Muslim-Yadav vote bank: this one is a gesture at the Bind/Nishad boatman community. The NDA relies on its core elite-caste vote combined with Anupriya's Kurmi cohorts—dominant OBCs, landed and prosperous, in these parts. But the 49 per cent OBC vote here also ticks much poorer parts of the spectrum—not to mention the 25 per cent Dalit-Adivasis. So, on a sweltering hot afternoon in Mirzapur on May 26, Modi told the crowds: "I grew up washing cups and plates and serving tea. The relationship between Modi and tea is very deep." That was also a broad hint at the AD(S) poll symbol: the cup-plate.

IN VARANASI, RAI MAY HAPPILY SEEK SOLACE IN A 'MORAL VICTORY' IF HE CAN EVEN TRIM PM MODI'S VICTORY MARGIN SLIGHTLY

The Gorakhpur contest sizzles with celeb power: the BJP's MP, Bhojpuri star Ravi Kishan, is up against another entertainment industry biggie: the Congress has fielded Bhojpuri film/TV actress Kajal Nishad. Ghazipur is witnessing a different kind of heat: the SP has fielded Afzal Ansari, brother of Mukhtar Ansari, the mafia don-politico who recently died in prison in unusual circumstances. The Ansari family's clout faces a stiff challenge from the BJP's Parasnath Rai. Though known more for his ties to the RSS than street-level politics, Rai is a trusted aide of former Ghazipur MP and present Jammu and Kashmir lieutenant governor Manoj Sinha. Besides all that inhouse firepower, Ghazipur, like Ghosi, has a significant Rajbhar population, so the BJP is also relying on the SBSP pulling its weight. But in the end, here and elsewhere, it may be down to the degree of ardour in the core saffron vote. ■